While the BJP was roundly criticised for its stance, it is important to note that the Congress took precisely the same position on this issue. The BJP's agitation against women activists trying to enter Sabarimala in November 2018 was matched by Congress–UDF leaders staging protests on precisely the same grounds at various places in Kerala, including a march led by former Kerala chief minister Oomen Chandy and Opposition leader Ramesh Chennithala from Nilakkal to Pamba.[155] The Congress's turn away from the liberal position was best articulated by Thiruvananthapuram MP Shashi Tharoor. Having initially welcomed the Supreme Court verdict, he later changed his mind, arguing that a 'significant majority of women' had demonstrated that their 'faith is offended by the Supreme Court verdict', and that it would be 'preposterous to tell women that their faith is really a form of Stockholm syndrome. When you disturb the belief of worshippers, you violate a space beyond reasoning.' He admitted that this left liberals like him 'torn', but insisted that in 'religious matters, beliefs must prevail'.[156] As Tharoor told me later in a public discussion, he changed his mind after he 'saw the reactions from my own people' whom he represented in Parliament and on 'seeing the depth of feeling, particularly among women'. As he put it, 'when you see it from the outside, you see it as an issue of equality and you frame it that way but from the point of believers … they frame it as an issue of sanctity', which would damage the centuries-old beliefs around the temple.[157] Rahul Gandhi too changed his position on Sabarimala after initially supporting the Supreme Court verdict. Shorn of all the spin, the Congress and the BJP were essentially saying the same thing.

The Sabarimala debate demonstrates how all Indian political parties are conflicted on questions of gender. In a political landscape characterised by double-speak on gender, the gaps in the BJP's discourse may not necessarily be a disadvantage—in comparison to the Congress—especially if it is doing more on the ground for the representation of women than the other parties are.

## The BJP's Mobilisation of Women and Questions for the Women's Movement